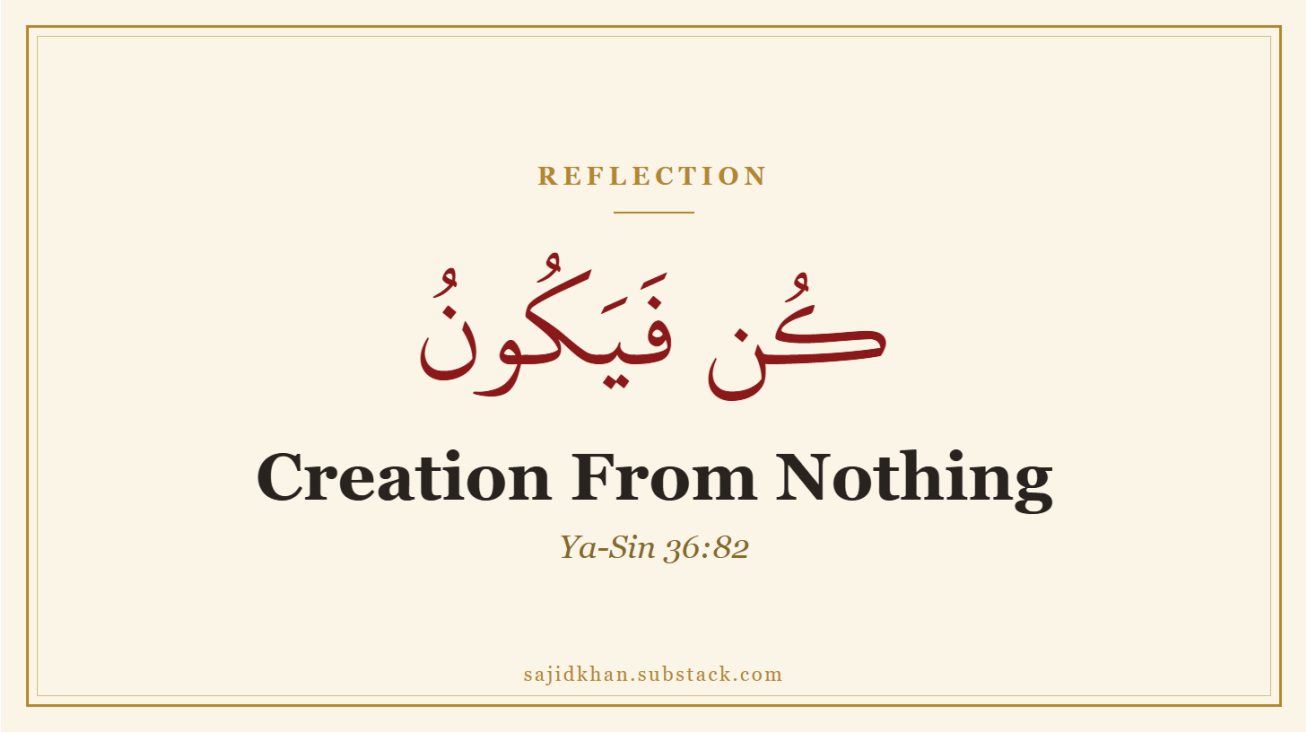


REFLECTION

Creation From Nothing

Physics, Iqbal, and "Be!"

Allah calls Himself فَاطِرِ السَّمَاوَاتِ وَالْأَرْضِ "the Originator of the heavens and the earth" (35:1). The word فَاطِر (*faatir*) means the one who brings something out for the first time, where there was nothing before.

What physics sees

Modern physics has found that even "empty" space is not really empty. In quantum field theory, a vacuum is full of tiny bursts of energy, and particles can briefly pop into existence and vanish again. These are not just numbers on paper; their effects have been measured in many experiments. At its deepest level, the physical world turns out to be far stranger, and far less solid, than it looks.

What Iqbal saw

Allama Iqbal, in *The Reconstruction of Religious Thought in Islam*, looked at how the early Muslim theologians, the Ash'aris, understood the atom. For them, an atom has no existence of its own. Existence is something Allah gives it, moment by moment. Before that, Iqbal writes, it

lies as if asleep "in the creative energy of God", and its existence is nothing more than "Divine energy become visible".

What the Qur'an says

In Surah Ya-Sin (36:82):

إِنَّمَا أَمْرُهُ إِذَا أَرَادَ شَيْئًا أَن يَقُولَ لَهُ كُن فَيَكُونُ ﴿٨٢﴾

"When He wills something, His command is only to say to it 'Be!', and it is."

Science describes *how* things appear. The Qur'an tells us *who* brings them into being, and that He never stops.

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